

enough on our part, but a lot of it also has to do with the low repairability of modern devices, coupled with difficulty in separating out parts from said devices by element.

When it comes to e-waste, perhaps the right to repair is less of a priority than your right to recycle! Not that there is any reason whatsoever to think we cannot do both together!

LEGISLATION ABROAD

Coming back to the right to repair legislation that's been in and out of politician's radar for quite a few years now...

Western countries especially seem to have more time on their hands, and care more about the 5 Rs – refuse, reduce, reuse, repurpose, recycle. And in that order of importance too! Of these 5 Rs, two of them (reuse and repurpose) can be thought of as a subset of repair. This is because there are elements of repair that go into both reusing a product, and also repurposing it.

As with all things climate change driven, the EU takes the lead as the most vocal of all governments in this regard. It was the EU that pushed for more eco-friendly designs, right from the amount of power a device uses,



This is a modular laptop by <https://frame.work> and it promises to be totally upgradeable and has the ultimate in repairability scores!

and how efficient it is, to the materials inside devices, how they were sourced, or mined, and generally scrutinising products and brands. The EU in 2019 passed a bill requiring manufacturers to make replacement parts for every

REPAIR CAFÉ

In case you haven't already heard of this, a Repair Café is a hands-on, DIY themed meeting spot where everyone from engineers to ordinary folk can come and attempt to repair something that's broken down. This could be learning how to mend a torn pair of trousers, to fixing one of the latest TVs. The Repair Café provides all the necessary tools and also a lot of colourful personalities who volunteer to help you repair or tell you how to repair the item you have brought in. You could trade services and repair something that no one else can, while someone else repairs your device, or you can just buy an expert a coffee and watch him fix your device (hopefully)!

Sadly, there's only one in all of India, which is in Bengaluru. We think more of you with the skills and tools to repair stuff should get together and start your own repair café. Just head over to repaircafe.org and register your interest to open one local to you.

device that is manufactured in 2021 and beyond, for a period of 10 years after launch! This means that the products launched in 2021 will need to provide spares to third party repair shops until at least 2031, so that if anyone wanted to use the devices, they would be able to.

In the US, the right to repair movement started with automotive vehicles in 2012, with a bill being passed that requires that automotive engineers and

end users alike, be given access to documentation and spare parts.

The UK has taken a slightly different stance here, and the Right to Repair law they drafted and implemented broke repairs up into two categories. One category was all of us laymen who are required to be given access to parts and manuals for repairs that the bill terms as "simple and safe". Since we have spoken about washing machines, this could mean the hinges of doors, the inlet and outlet pipes, panels, etc. Professional repair shops are to

be given comprehensive access to even complex spare parts that only experts in the field can install.

INDIA

We can only imagine the reduction

we could see in our e-waste if things were more modular, and easier to take apart. Of course we're not advocating for a totally modular design on laptops, even if that very concept is gaining popularity with some brands such as Framework (<https://frame.work>) attempting to build a totally modular laptop that's completely user customisable, and encourages users to tinker with the innards, just as PC users have been doing all their lives.

With spare parts being made available, a right to repair law could enable us to be able to reuse, repair and repurpose technology devices to increase technology penetration rapidly across the country. These second-hand devices could really revolutionise the country, instead of going into a landfill, or worse, the resulting toxic waste being handled by children!

The great thing about India is that no one really has a monopoly here, and people still choose which gadget to buy based on price first, and performance and reputation of the brand a close second. Such a legislation, if made now, would ruffle far fewer feathers here, than in America, or many of the developed countries where one brand usually dominates the market, and as a result, also controls the agenda.

This fight has only just begun though, and it depends a lot on what we consumers decide to do about it. Most of Team Digit are for it, which side of the fence are you standing? Remember to send us feedback. 